

MSI NX6800GT SLI

When you buy a high-end 3D graphics card, you want the card to play the latest games for the next few years. Alas, newer technologies develop, and in just about a couple of years, your 3D graphics card buckles under the pressure of the ever-increasing polygons that are demanded by newer games, and you feel your card, which was high-end just a couple of years ago, is no longer a worthy gaming card.

nVidia has looked at the past and has reintroduced a scalable solution for this problem, known as SLI—Scalable Link Interface—which was the brainchild of 3DFX in the late 1990s. In an SLI setup, two graphics cards are mounted on an SLI-ready motherboard and connected to each other by a bridge. This enables them to work in tandem and deliver up to twice the performance of a single card. The bandwidth between the cards and the CPU still remains the same as that of a single card, because each card is limited to work at x8 speed instead of the x16 speed of a single card.

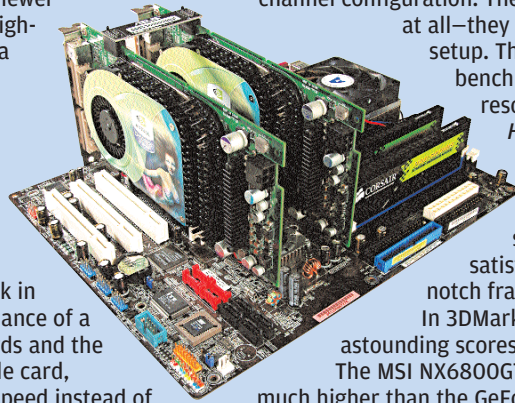
The MSI NX6800GT SLI is a pair of GeForce 6800GT 256 MB cards which can be connected in SLI configuration. These cards came in a nice carry case with some bundled games and OEM

software. Two DVI to VGA adapters, power and S-Video cables were also provided.

It was mounted on an nForce4 SLI motherboard with an AMD Athlon64 FX-53 and 1 GB of Corsair XMS DDR RAM in dual-channel configuration. The benchmark results did not surprise us at all—they were what we expected from an SLI setup. The pair delivered fluid frames in all the benchmarks even at the highest possible resolution. At 1,600 x 1,200 in *Doom 3*, *Half-Life 2* and *FarCry*, the frames per second logged were 128.6, 85.14 and 122.10 respectively. Even with all the eye-candy cranked up, the SLI setup's hunger for polygons was not satisfied, and it continued to deliver top-notch frame rates.

In 3DMark 03 and 3DMark 05, the cards posted astounding scores of 19,282 and 9,045 respectively.

The MSI NX6800GT SLI is priced at Rs 61,000, which is much higher than the GeForce 7800 GTX's price of Rs 35,000. The MSI NX6800GT SLI beats the GeForce 6800 GTX in the 3DMark benchmarks, but lags in the gaming benchmarks. If you are a hardcore gamer, and demand the highest gaming performance, SLI is the way to go.

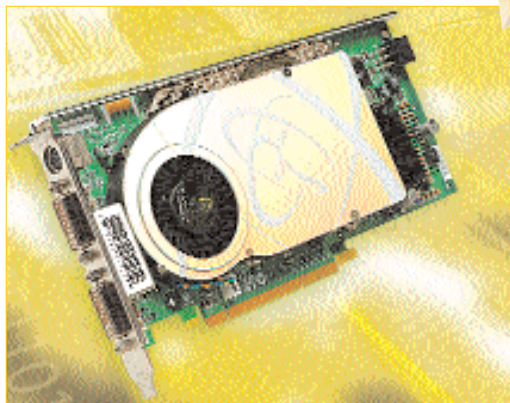


system on their ATi X800 card. The cooling was, however, not very efficient, and the heat-sink temperature soared when while testing it.

The XFX GeForce 7800GTX was a pleasure to test. Talk about adrenaline rushes... this one will get yours into overdrive! It scored a massive 16,649 points in 3DMark 2003 and 7,942 points in 3DMark 2005, second only to the SLI and Dual GPU monsters. At 2,048 x 1,536 in *Half-Life 2*, we could barely manage to read the text on the monitor, but this card effortlessly shoved a score of 86 frames per second at our incredulous faces.

The processing power of the GPU is the what needs to be given the credit here. In the 7800GTX core—the G70—the number of transistors on the die has gone through the roof. The performance boost here is due to the effective implementation of the G70 architecture and the DDR3 video RAM.

Although it lost out in the 3DMark tests, the 7800GTX beat the pants off the competition in the game tests. Just take a look at the scores table—the rest of the cards didn't stand a chance!



XFX GeForce 6800GT
256 MB

XFX GeForce 7800 GTX
256 MB

The next-best card was the 6800 Ultra, which stood up to its reputation of a pixel cruncher. The ATi cards put up a brave front, especially the PowerColor X850XT PE, which was able to take on the XFX and MSI 6800GTs.

All the other cards ended up like extras on the set, never making their presence felt. The XFX GeForce 7800GTX was the show-stealer.

Conclusion

Given the excellent performance of the XFX 7800GTX, we expected it to be expensive. However, the price will put a smile on your face: it retails for just Rs 35,000. The XFX GeForce 7800GTX wins the Digit Best Buy Gold crown in our graphics card comparison in the high-end category.

The XFX GeForce 6800GT is the runner-up. It provides blazing fast frame rates which, although not comparable to the 7800, are fast enough to let you play any game on it. At Rs 23,000, this card takes the Digit Best Buy Silver crown for the high-end graphics card category.

